LEXIN CAI

lexincai@ucla.edu https://lexincai.github.io

CURRENT EMPLOYMENT

2026- Postdoctoral Scholar
UCLA California Center for Population Research
Mentor: Martha Bailey

EDUCATION

2026 Ph.D. in Economics, Cornell University
Committee: Zhuan Pei, Maria Fitzpatrick, Pauline Leung, Benjamin Goldman

2015 M.S. in Social Policy, University of Pennsylvania

2013 B.S. in Public Administration, Renmin University of China

WORKING PAPERS

"From Means-Tested to Universal: Short- and Long-Run Effects of Free School Meals"

"Screening Out the Needy: The Effects of SNAP Work Requirements"
(with Hyewon Kim and Pauline Leung)

"When Free Lunch Is No Longer a Proxy for Student Poverty: Effects of the Community Eligibility Provision on State K-12 Funding"

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Who is Financially Constrained? How Out-of-Pocket Costs Shape Contraceptive Use, Pregnancy, and Childbirth"
(with Martha Bailey, Emilia Brito, and Giulia Olivero)

"The Effects of Subsidizing Contraception on Educational and Labor Market Outcomes"
(with Martha Bailey, Emilia Brito, and Giulia Olivero)

"Work Requirements in SNAP and Postsecondary Enrollment"
(with Meredith Welch)

PRESENTATIONS

2027 ASSA Annual Meeting (poster)
2026 ASSA Annual Meeting, Institute for Research on Poverty Summer Research Workshop (poster, UW–Madison), National Tax Association Annual Meeting, Ohio State University, Minneapolis Fed, U.S. International Trade Commission, Penn Wharton Budget Model, Mathematica, Analysis Group
2025 APPAM, Association for Education Finance and Policy, FLX Economics of Education Workshop (Cornell), Policy Impacts Annual Conference (MIT), Society for Benefit-Cost Analysis (SBCA), Symposium on the Frontiers in the Studies of Anti-Poverty Programs (Discussant, Cornell)
2024 APPAM

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

2025–2026	Ernest Liu '64, Ta-Chung and Ya-Chao Liu Memorial Fellowship, Cornell
2025	Jerry Ellig Award for Best Student Presentation, SBCA Annual Meeting
2023–2024	Jain Family Institute – Cornell Brooks School Fellow
2022	Outstanding TA Award, Cornell Brooks School of Public Policy
2020–2025	Sage Fellowship, Cornell University (x2)
2014	Dean's Merit Award, University of Pennsylvania
2012	Global KU Scholarship, Korea University
2010–2013	National Scholarship, Renmin University of China (x3, top 5%)

TEACHING

Spring 2022	TA for Behavioral Economics and Public Policy, Cornell University
Fall 2021	TA for Economics of the Public Sector, Cornell University

RESEARCH GRANTS

2025	Russell Sage Foundation Dissertation Research Grant ($15K)
2024	MIT Policy Impacts Early-Career Scholars Grant ($10K)
2024	Cornell Labor Economics Small Grant ($2.5K)

EMPLOYMENT

2022–2024	Cornell University Research Assistant to Prof. Pauline Leung and Prof. Zhuan Pei
2015–2020	Center on Budget and Policy Priorities Research Analyst (2018–2020), Associate (2016–2018), Intern (2015–2016)
2014–2015	World Wildlife Fund Intern

SERVICE

2022–2025	Executive Board Member, Diversity in Cornell Economics
2022–2024	Student Representative, Cornell Economics Committee for Student and Faculty Engagement
2021–2022	Social Co-chair, Cornell Graduate Students in Public Policy
2014–2015	Co-founder, Wonk Tank, Penn Wharton Public Policy Initiative

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Data clearance	U.S. Census Bureau Special Sworn Status (2022-present)
Languages	English, Cantonese, Mandarin Chinese
Citizenship	United States

Last updated October 2026